Rose’s hand.

“I’ll explain it once we’re inside.” Paulette’s small hand inside her own made Rose’s heart swell. Paulette was so young, Rose hoped that she would always be protected from the danger lurking all around on account of the war, just like Léa had done for her. Rose glanced at her sister before gathering up the basket.

That evening, Virginie allowed Paulette to skip her chores of peeling the potatoes and setting the table so she could help Rose with the arrangement of the still life. Virginie had given her permission to move the chairs under the window, placing a wooden table there instead. Paulette had found a blue velvet cloth in the attic upstairs and she and Rose had brushed the dust off it outside. Now, they draped the velvet material over the wooden table.

“It’s the color of a *mésange bleue*, isn’t it?” Virginie said, entering the room and staring at the table. “Come, dinner is ready. You two can work on the still life tomorrow.”

“But I have school.” Paulette frowned.

Rose gently pinched Paulette’s nose between her first and second finger then withdrew, showing her thumb. “I caught your nose.” She laughed.

Paulette shrieked and touched her nose. “No, you didn’t.”

“You can help me after school. I’ll wait for you.”

Paulette smiled, took Rose’s hand and together they followed her mother into the kitchen.